brief, but we have no other source, first-hand or otherwise, to capture the Big Bang moment of the formation of the company.

VOC's detailed Appeal ('*vignapanam*') of 25 August, while providing the rationale for launching the company also broke down the economics of the venture.[17] In ancient times, India was a great economic power with considerable maritime prowess, rivalling if not eclipsing other maritime nations. The maritime and naval exploits of the Cholas were unknown at that time and therefore find no mention in the appeal. (It was only in the mid-1930s that K.A. Nilakanta Sastri's *The Colas* was published. Kalki's historical romance, *Ponniyin Selvan* published in serial form in the early 1950s, drawing extensively on Sastri's classic work, was largely responsible for popularizing Chola fame.) But once India was overcome by foreigners it became mired in poverty. However, due to 'divine intervention,' on 7 August 1905,[18] the Swadeshi movement was born. Indians forged a new unity and began to progress in the world of commerce and industry. Of all industries, it was imperative that Indians take the initiative in seaborne trade as it was the most profitable. All that was required to profit from the Tuticorin–Colombo trade was a couple of steamers and steam launches, to purchase which Rs 5 lakh was adequate. Even discounting all expenses, annual profits would be to the tune of Rs 10 lakh. With their monopoly over this trade, foreigners were exploiting and impoverishing the southern country. Since shipping was the conduit through which India's alien rulers funnelled their profits, it was imperative that Indians take control of the global maritime trade. Running the Tuticorin–Colombo route was only the beginning. VOC asked rhetorically:

> Brothers! Do we not have five lakh rupees to buy two steamships and two steam launches! Do we not have the capacity to run these ships? Did our ancestors ever lag behind in running shipping vessels? Are not all the commodities that are being imported and exported our own goods? Except for the odd passenger are not all the passengers our own people?

Brimming with confidence and pride, he proclaimed that 'We are capable of not only plying the Tuticorin–Colombo route but to all the ports and